

BEFORE

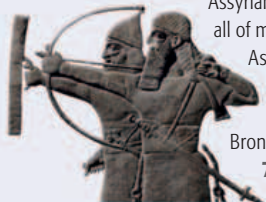
Assyria rose to prominence in northern Mesopotamia << 54–55 in the 14th century BCE, but its foundations were laid by rulers up to 600 years earlier.

OLD ASSYRIAN PERIOD

The Assyrian Empire's roots can be traced to the period c. 2000–1800 BCE when **Shamshi-Adad I** created a kingdom including the great trading city of **Ashur**, once an independent **city-state**.

MIDDLE ASSYRIAN PERIOD

By 1400 BCE, the Assyrians were vassals of their powerful neighbor, the **kingdom of Mittani** << 78–79. As Mittani crumbled, Ashur broke free, its rulers proclaiming themselves “**kings of Assyria**.” Under Ashur-uballit I (1365–1330 BCE), Assyrian lands expanded over all of modern north Iraq, and Assyria came into conflict with Babylonia and the Hittites. Like other Bronze Age powers << 78–79, Assyria declined in the 11th century BCE, but the state survived.



ASSYRIAN SOLDIERS

The Assyrians were Semitic people living in northern Mesopotamia (modern Iraq) and they reached the height of their empire—during the “Neo-Assyrian” era—in the 800s and 700s BCE. The Neo-Assyrian Empire built on the foundations of the Middle Assyrian period (1350–1000 BCE, see BEFORE), during which Assyria commanded much wealth and resources, improving agriculture and irrigation, erecting impressive buildings, and establishing key administrative centres.

Legendary warriors

The Neo-Assyrians were famed as fierce warriors and they showed innovative military prowess, which helped them to expand their territories. Chariot warfare had already become established during the Middle Assyrian period, when the Middle East was still in the Bronze Age (see pp.78–79). However, military success in the Neo-Assyrian period was aided by the Assyrians’ effective adoption of new Iron Age warfare techniques. Their highly disciplined army featured a mix of chariots, infantry, and horseback

Life in an Assyrian military camp

This 9th-century relief from Ashurnasirpal II’s palace at Nimrud shows a priest, bottom left, preparing to predict the future by studying a sheep’s entrails. Foretelling the future was a prominent aspect of Assyrian life.

population movements were more like resettlements than deportations, because the people were given land and state assistance. This resettlement was the fate of the people known in Biblical tradition as the “Ten Lost Tribes” of the conquered Hebrew kingdom of Israel. They were moved to the Upper Habur area of northern Mesopotamia and the Zagros mountains of southwest Iran.

SEMITIC A language group that includes Hebrew and Arabic, and a description of people from the Middle East who trace their ancestry to the biblical Noah and his son, Shem. The group includes both Jews and Arabs.

Food, probably a meat stew (perhaps from the butchered sheep), is being prepared on a stove.



An Assyrian priest, recognizable by his hat, joins another man in butchering a sheep so that he can “read” its entrails.

Coded signs written by the gods were believed to be hidden in sheep’s entrails.

Rulers of the Iron Age

By the 9th century BCE, a great Assyrian empire dominated the Middle East and stayed in control for two centuries. It is often seen as the first real “world empire,” and much of its success can be traced to a stable political system and skillful exploitation of new Iron Age warfare techniques.

ASSYRIAN KING, RULED 721–705 BCE

SARGON II

Coming to the throne in suspicious circumstances, Sargon II probably had a hand in the disposal of his brother and predecessor, Shalmaneser V. Sargon consolidated the gains of his father, Tiglath-pileser III, in Babylonia and the Mediterranean, and further enlarged the empire to Iran and far into Anatolia. With a vast workforce from all over the Middle East at his command and heavy tribute and taxes filling his coffers, Sargon built a new residence city called Sargon’s Fortress (modern Khorsabad) in the Assyrian heartland—its palaces and temples bearing lavish stonework.



riders. This was the first army to use cavalry units, which, along with the Assyrians’ use of iron weapons, gave them a great advantage over less advanced enemies. The fighting forces mixed a standing army of professional soldiers (including foreign mercenaries) under the control of the king with provincial contingents mustered as part of regional tax obligations.

Creating an empire

Famed too for the barbaric subjugation of their enemies, the Assyrians used impalement, mass execution, and the ruthless mass “deportation” of those who opposed them. But such methods were also used by other powers throughout the Middle East. The Assyrians certainly invented a new way of dealing with conquered people by moving them en masse to other parts of the empire and replacing them with other people from within the empire. However, the

Resettlement was designed to create a uniform population, although it created some hotbeds of dissent. The policy also made central Assyria a cultural melting pot. By the 7th century BCE, the royal entourage included scholars, craftsmen, and singers from Babylonia, Anatolia, Egypt, and Iran.

Stable foundations

Military effectiveness was crucially backed up by a relatively stable political system. Various factors contributed to this. The first was the royal bloodline, which was considered all-important, so that outsiders could not become king. A crown prince and heir apparent was selected as soon as a new king took the throne. There was always a successor, and he played an important role in running the empire. If the king died unexpectedly, the succession arrangement was already in place.

Second was the way in which power was delegated from the king to local officials. Assyria was organized into



Regional power

Assyrian governors often enjoyed great wealth. This mural detail is from a governor’s residence at Til Barsip, during the reign of Tiglath-pileser III (744–727 BCE).